

pilation. The question is even seriously discussed whether this "author" (1) made up his book from our canonical Greek version of Chronicles-Ezra-Nehemiah; or (2) made use of an independent Greek version; or (3) made his own translation from the Hebrew-Aramaic original. That he made his "compilation" in Greek is taken for granted, since it is the general belief that the interpolated Story of the Three Youths, as we have it, is not a translation from a Semitic original. It is a fact that speaks volumes for the general neglect of the book, that Schürer in both the first and second editions of his *Geschichte* maintained the view that First Esdras was compiled from our canonical Greek Old Testament—though any well-equipped university student could demonstrate the contrary to a certainty by an afternoon's work on any chapter in the book.

To illustrate a little further the current view, and the treatment now given to this "apocryphon" by Old Testament scholars: The DeWette-Schrader *Einleitung* (8th ed., 1869, p. 565) bravely confessed inability to recognize the purpose of the "author" of First Esdras in compiling it, remarking: "Ein Zweck dieser characterlosen Compilation lässt sich nicht entdecken;" but the great majority are content to repeat over, each from his fellow, Bertholdt's naïve hypothesis that the writer intended to provide a history of the temple from the latter part of the regal period down to the time when the cultus had been restored. Kusters, in his *Wiederherstellung Israels in der persischen Periode* (German trans. by Basedow, pp. 124-26), unfolded a much more elaborate theory—with even less support from the document itself. Of course, the abrupt ending of the "book" (in the middle of a sentence!) has been generally noticed, though few have made any attempt to explain it. Ewald's conjecture, that the work was left unfinished by "its author," is frequently repeated, e. g., by Strack, *Einleitung*⁴, p. 152 ("Das Buch, welches von seinem Verfasser nicht vollendet worden zu sein scheint," etc.), and by Guthe, in Kautzsch's *Apokryphen des A. T.*, p. 2. In most textbooks of Introduction to the Old Testament First Esdras is ignored—as though it stood in no close relation to the Old Testament!—and this, too, even by those who profess to believe that it represents a Hebrew-Aramaic text differing in many respects from our massoretic recension. In Cornill's *Einleitung*⁵, for example, it receives not a syllable of mention. In Driver's